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# Counting without missing anything

Level 2 Intermediate · Combinatorics

*Count arrangements and selections reliably with the multiplication principle, factorials, choosing, complementary counting and well-organised casework.*

**By the end you can:** You will be able to count arrangements and selections with the multiplication principle, factorials and $\binom{n}{r}$; You will be able to handle conditions by filling restricted places first, gluing blocks, using gaps or counting the complement; You will be able to organise casework and systematic lists so that nothing is missed or counted twice.

## Lesson

Here is a question that looks like routine work: *how many of the whole numbers from 1 to 999 contain at least one digit 5?* The natural first attempt is to split by position. A 5 in the units place: 100 numbers. A 5 in the tens place: another 100. A 5 in the hundreds place: another 100. So 300? No. The number 555 has been counted three times and 505 twice. You could patch this up, but there is a much cleaner way in.

Write every number from 0 to 999 as a three-digit string by adding leading zeros, so 7 becomes 007. Now each number is simply a choice of three digits, and there are $10 \times 10 \times 10 = 1000$ strings. The strings with *no* 5 have 9 options in each place, so there are $9^3 = 729$ of them, and one of these is 000, which is not in our range. So 728 of the numbers from 1 to 999 avoid the digit 5, and the answer is $999 - 728 = 271$.

Two ideas did all the work: describe each object as a sequence of choices, and count what you do not want when that is easier. This unit builds those habits, so that you count every object once and only once.

### The multiplication principle

> **Multiplication principle.** Suppose every object you are counting is built by making a first choice in $a$ ways, then a second choice in $b$ ways, then a third in $c$ ways, and so on, where the *number* of options at each stage does not depend on what was chosen earlier, and different sequences of choices give different objects. Then there are $a \times b \times c \times \cdots$ objects.

Why is it true? Draw the choices as a tree. The first stage gives $a$ branches, each of those splits into $b$, so there are $ab$ branches after two stages, and so on. Each complete path is one object, and each object is one path.

Both conditions in the box matter. The second (different choices give different objects) fails if you count pairs of socks as "first sock, then second sock", since each pair arises twice. The first fails all the time with digits. Count the four-digit odd numbers with all digits different. Going left to right, the first digit has 9 options (not 0), the second 9 and the third 8, but the number of options for the last digit (odd and unused) depends on how many odd digits have already been used. The fix is to **make the most restricted choice first**. The units digit has 5 options, then the leading digit has 8 (not 0 and not the units digit), then the hundreds digit has 8 and the tens digit 7, giving $5 \times 8 \times 8 \times 7 = 2240$.

Alongside it sits the **addition principle**: if the objects split into cases with no overlap, count each case and add. Most real problems use both. Split into cases, then multiply inside each case.



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## Arrangements and choices

The number of ways to arrange $n$ different objects in a row is $n! = n(n-1)\cdots 2\cdot 1$, since there are $n$ options for the first place, $n-1$ for the second, and so on. If you only fill $r$ places, you get $n(n-1)\cdots(n-r+1) = \dfrac{n!}{(n-r)!}$ ordered selections.

Often order does not matter: a team, a hand of cards, a set of squares to shade. Each unordered set of $r$ objects can be put in order in $r!$ ways, so among the ordered selections every set has been counted exactly $r!$ times. Dividing out the overcount gives the key formula.

> The number of ways to choose $r$ objects from $n$ different objects, when order does not matter, is
>
> $$\binom{n}{r} = \frac{n!}{r!\,(n-r)!}.$$
>
> Also $\binom{n}{r} = \binom{n}{n-r}$, since choosing the $r$ objects you take is the same as choosing the $n-r$ you leave behind.

The same "label, count, then divide" idea handles repeated letters. To arrange the letters of LEVEL, pretend they are $L_1, E_1, V, E_2, L_2$. There are $5! = 120$ arrangements of these, and each genuine word appears $2!\times 2! = 4$ times (swap the Ls, swap the Es), so there are $120/4 = 30$ words. Dividing is only safe when every object is overcounted the same number of times, which is worth checking each time.

Know a few values by heart: $\binom{n}{2} = \frac{n(n-1)}{2}$, $\binom{6}{3} = 20$ and $\binom{8}{4} = 70$.

## Restrictions: tame the awkward part first

Most contest counting questions are a standard count plus a condition. Four tools cover nearly all of them at this level.

- **Restricted places first.** As with the odd numbers above, fill the places with the fewest options before the free ones.
- **Glue.** If certain objects must be together, tape them into one block, arrange the blocks, then multiply by the number of orders inside the block.
- **Gaps.** If certain objects must be apart, arrange everything else first. Then $k$ objects in a row create $k+1$ gaps (counting both ends), and putting the restricted objects into different gaps keeps them apart.
- **Complement.** If the condition says "at least one" or "not all", count everything and subtract the objects that fail.

Finally, **systematic listing** is a genuine method, not a last resort. When the total is small, say under 30, list in a fixed order (alphabetical, or by the first entry) so that you can see the list is complete. An organised list is a proof; a disorganised one is a guess.

> **Example 1.** How many three-digit even numbers greater than 500 have all three digits different?
>
> *Solution.*
> The restricted places are the first digit (5, 6, 7, 8 or 9) and the last digit (0, 2, 4, 6 or 8). Try filling them first: 5 options for the first digit, then the last digit, but how many even digits are still free depends on whether the first digit was even. That dependence is the signal to split into cases.
> If the first digit is odd (5, 7 or 9), the last digit can be any of the 5 even digits, and the middle

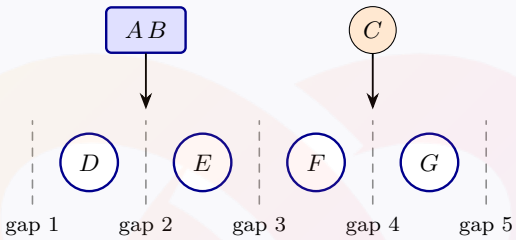


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digit is any of the 8 digits not yet used, giving $3 \times 5 \times 8 = 120$. If the first digit is even (6 or 8), the last digit has only 4 options, and the middle again has 8, giving $2 \times 4 \times 8 = 64$. The cases do not overlap, so the total is $120 + 64 = 184$.
Notice that the middle digit was left until last on purpose. It has 8 options whatever happens, so it never causes trouble.

**Example 2.** Seven people, including Asha, Ben and Cara, sit in a row of seven chairs. Asha and Ben insist on sitting next to each other, and neither of them will sit next to Cara. In how many ways can the seven sit?

*Solution.*
"Next to each other" says glue, and "not next to" says gaps. Glue Asha and Ben into one block, which can be AB or BA, so there are 2 internal orders. Now seat the four other people (call them D, E, F and G) in $4! = 24$ ways. They create 5 gaps: before the first, between neighbours, and after the last.




The block and Cara must go into *different* gaps, since sharing a gap would put Cara beside the block. That gives $5 \times 4 = 20$ ordered choices of gaps. Every valid seating arises exactly once, so the total is $2 \times 24 \times 20 = 960$.
It is worth checking by a second route. With Asha and Ben glued there are $2 \times 6! = 1440$ seatings in all. In the bad ones Cara sits at one end of the block, forming a block of three: CAB, CBA, ABC or BAC. There are 4 such triples and $5! = 120$ ways to arrange the five units, so 480 bad seatings, and indeed $1440 - 480 = 960$. Two independent methods agreeing is the best check there is.

**Example 3.** A committee of 4 is chosen from 6 boys and 5 girls. In how many ways can this be done if the committee must include at least one boy and at least one girl?

*Solution.*
A tempting idea is to guarantee the condition directly: choose a boy (6 ways), choose a girl (5 ways), then choose any 2 of the remaining 9 pupils ($\binom{9}{2} = 36$ ways), giving $6 \times 5 \times 36 = 1080$. That is more than $\binom{11}{4} = 330$, the number of committees with no condition at all, so something is badly wrong. A committee with two boys and two girls is produced once for each choice of "guaranteed" boy and "guaranteed" girl, so it is counted 4 times, while a committee with three of one sex is counted 3 times. The overcount is not even uniform, so you cannot divide it away. The condition fails only when the committee is all boys or all girls, so count the complement instead. There are $\binom{6}{4} = 15$ all-boy committees and $\binom{5}{4} = 5$ all-girl ones, so the answer is $330 - 15 - 5 = 310$.

**Example 4.** A digital clock shows the time in the 24-hour format HH:MM, from 00:00 to 23:59. For how many minutes of the day are the four digits on display all different?

*Solution.*
A left-to-right count stalls at once: after the hour is fixed, the number of options for the first



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minute digit (0 to 5) depends on whether the hour digits lie among 0 to 5. So split into cases according to the hour, and inside each case use the multiplication principle.
Fix the hour first, with its two digits different. The first hour digit is always 0, 1 or 2, so it always uses up one of the six digits 0 to 5. If the second hour digit is also at most 5, the first minute digit has $6-2=4$ options; if the second hour digit is 6 or more, it has $6-1=5$. Either way the last digit then has $10-3=7$ options.
Now count hours. With first digit 0, the second digit is 1 to 9: five of these (1 to 5) are at most 5 and four (6 to 9) are bigger, giving $5\times4\times7+4\times5\times7=280$. First digit 1 works the same way, with second digit 0 or 2 to 9, giving another 280. First digit 2 allows only 20, 21 and 23, all with second digit at most 5, giving $3\times4\times7=84$. The total is $280+280+84=644$.
The lesson is in the structure. We split on the one feature (is the second hour digit small?) that changed the count, and on nothing else.

**Common traps.**

- Multiplying when the number of options at a stage depends on earlier choices. Leading zeros are the classic case.
- Counting ordered selections when the question wants unordered ones, or the reverse. Ask: would swapping two chosen objects give a different answer to the question?
- "Guarantee one, then choose the rest freely." This almost always overcounts, as in Example 3.
- Forgetting the internal orders of a glued block, or forgetting the two end gaps.
- Cases that overlap, such as "the first digit is 5" and "the last digit is 5". Cases must split the objects with no overlap.
- Fence-post errors: there are $300-100+1=201$ integers from 100 to 300 inclusive, not 200.

### How to spot this in a contest

Almost every question beginning "how many ways" or "how many numbers" lives in this unit. Before computing anything, decide what a single object looks like and write one down; this alone fixes most order-versus-no-order confusion. Then scan the conditions. "Different" or "distinct" suggests the multiplication principle with shrinking options, "next to" suggests glue, "not next to" suggests gaps, and "at least one" suggests the complement.

When the numbers are small, count a smaller version by hand and test your method on it. If your method says there are 6 ways to seat three people in a row with two particular people apart, and listing shows only 2, you have found your mistake before it cost you marks. On the IMC and the Kangaroos the options are often close together, so a method that is nearly right is simply wrong.

## Practice

Try each problem before turning to the hints and solutions at the back.

1. ⋆ A password consists of two different letters chosen from A, B, C, D, E and F, followed by three digits, the last of which is odd. How many different passwords are possible?

2. ⋆⋆ How many three-digit numbers have at least two digits that are equal?



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3. ⋆⋆ In how many of the different arrangements of the eight letters of the word TEETOTAL are the three Ts next to each other?

4. ⋆⋆⋆ Eight chairs stand in a row. Three people, Dev, Eli and Fay, sit down so that no two of them are in neighbouring chairs. In how many ways can this happen?

5. ⋆⋆⋆ A 5 by 5 grid of unit squares is drawn. How many rectangles whose sides lie along the lines of the grid are *not* squares?

6. ⋆⋆⋆⋆ How many four-digit numbers use exactly two different digits? (For example, 3383 and 7070 do, but 3333 and 1231 do not.)

## Contest ladder

Real past problems that use this idea, easiest first. Open them on the official paper or the AoPS wiki, or online at kevinvariant08.github.io.

1. UKMT Pink Kangaroo 2019 Question 5 ⋆
2. UKMT Grey Kangaroo 2022 Question 6 ⋆
3. AMC 10A 2017 Problem 8 ⋆⋆
4. UKMT IMC 2019 Question 4 ⋆⋆
5. AMC 10A 2015 Problem 10 ⋆⋆
6. AMC 10A 2006 Problem 21 ⋆⋆
7. UKMT IMC 2015 Question 20 ⋆⋆
8. AMC 10A 2018 Problem 4 ⋆⋆
9. UKMT IMC 2017 Question 23 ⋆⋆⋆
10. AMC 8 2011 Problem 23 ⋆⋆⋆
11. UKMT Pink Kangaroo 2022 Question 17 ⋆⋆⋆
12. UKMT IMC 2015 Question 23 ⋆⋆⋆



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## Hints

1. Build a password one character at a time. Does any choice affect the number of options for a later one?
2. Count the three-digit numbers whose digits are all different, and work from there.
3. Glue the three Ts into a single block. Which of the remaining letters are identical?
4. Think of the five empty chairs as already placed. Where can the three people go?
5. A rectangle is fixed by its two vertical sides and its two horizontal sides. How many grid lines are there in each direction?
6. Choose the two digits first, then decide which digit goes in each place. Treat the case where one of the two digits is 0 separately.

## Solutions

### Problem 1

**Answer:** 15000

The first letter can be any of the 6 letters and the second any of the other 5, giving $6 \times 5 = 30$ ways to choose the letters in order. The first two digits can each be any of the 10 digits, and the last digit must be one of the 5 odd digits, giving $10 \times 10 \times 5 = 500$ ways. By the multiplication principle there are $30 \times 500 = 15000$ passwords.

### Problem 2

**Answer:** 252

There are $999 - 100 + 1 = 900$ three-digit numbers. Those with all three digits different are counted by choosing the first digit (9 options, not 0), then the second (9 options, any digit except the first), then the third (8 options), which gives $9 \times 9 \times 8 = 648$. Every other three-digit number has at least two equal digits, so the answer is $900 - 648 = 252$.

### Problem 3

**Answer:** 360

Since the Ts are identical, the three of them together form a single block TTT with only one internal order. We are then arranging six objects: the block, E, E, O, A and L. If the two Es were different there would be $6! = 720$ arrangements, but swapping the Es gives the same word, so each word has been counted twice. The answer is $720/2 = 360$.

### Problem 4

**Answer:** 120

Read a seating from left to right as a row of 5 empty chairs and 3 people. The 5 empty chairs create 6 gaps (one at each end and four between neighbouring empty chairs). No two people are neighbours exactly when the three people lie in three different gaps, with at most one person per gap. So a seating is determined by choosing which 3 of the 6 gaps are used, which can be done in $\binom{6}{3} = 20$



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ways, and then deciding which person goes in which chosen gap, which can be done in $3! = 6$ ways. Each seating arises exactly once this way, so there are $20 \times 6 = 120$ seatings.

## Problem 5

**Answer:** 170

The grid has 6 vertical lines and 6 horizontal lines. A rectangle is determined by choosing two of the vertical lines for its left and right sides and two of the horizontal lines for its top and bottom, and different choices give different rectangles. So there are $\binom{6}{2} \times \binom{6}{2} = 15 \times 15 = 225$ rectangles.

A $k$ by $k$ square can be placed with its bottom left corner in $(6-k)^2$ positions, so the number of squares is $5^2+4^2+3^2+2^2+1^2 = 55$. The number of rectangles that are not squares is $225-55 = 170$.

## Problem 6

**Answer:** 567

First suppose neither of the two digits is 0. There are $\binom{9}{2} = 36$ ways to choose the pair of digits. Each of the four places can then hold either digit, giving $2^4 = 16$ patterns, but two of these patterns use only one digit, so 14 patterns use both. This case gives $36 \times 14 = 504$ numbers.

Now suppose one of the two digits is 0 and the other is $d$, where $d$ can be any of 1 to 9. The first digit cannot be 0, so it must be $d$. Each of the remaining three places can be 0 or $d$, giving $2^3 = 8$ patterns, and only one of these (all $d$) fails to use 0. This case gives $9 \times 7 = 63$ numbers.

The two cases do not overlap and together cover every possibility, so the total is $504 + 63 = 567$.



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